

VIDEO GAME REHAB

Playing for almost 20 hours a day, Callum ranked seventh of seven million people who play World of Warcraft, ending up at reStart. reStart is US' first residential center for digital addiction that helps you get rid of video game addictions. Here's his complete story: <http://dgit.in/VGRehab>

LIFE IN A MARTIAN COLONY

"When we emerge on 28 August 2016, we'll be veterans of the longest NASA-funded Mars simulation in history." We wonder why a space architect, an engineer, three scientists and a crew doctor are living the "Life on Mars", well, actually on sMars. <http://dgit.in/MarsSim>

WHERE DO ALL THE DEFECTED IPHONES GO?

At an undisclosed place in Hong Kong, under tight security, is a place where Apple has been grinding and recycling all its iPhones. But not all of the defect ones make it to the dumping yard. So what happens to these defected iPhones? <http://dgit.in/iEWaste>

LIFE OF AN APP

Thousands of apps are listed on various app stores daily but just a fraction of them end up successfully get the audience attention and the fame. Here is a timeline of an app, the phases it passes through—starting from the idea of its creation to its death. <http://dgit.in/LifeOfApp>

SHORTS

Technology Addiction: Myth or Reality?

Overuse of technology is considered the new normal these days but facts prove otherwise. A lethal addiction has been on the rise since the invention of the internet. Now, it's at the brink of an explosion.

– By Adamya Sharma



Remember the familiar sight of a person walking with a bulky old stereo system literally stuck to their ears? Or when as children we were scolded for being stuck to the idiot box, paralysed in awe of our favourite cartoons and magical robot children (Small Wonder fans would know)? Those of you looking for a more current example, remember that time your dinner date was buried in his/her smartphone, leaving you no option but to Instagram food pictures for entertainment?

The keywords to take home here are - 'stuck', 'buried' and of course - 'entertainment.' For time immemorial, human beings have succumbed themselves to countless health problems thanks to their constant need for entertainment. Early man would draw on rocks for visual entertainment and expression, kings and queens would court jesters and performers to keep themselves in high spirits.

With time, came the age of the devices. Radios and television sets had parents and teachers worried worldover. Finally, came the internet and the rest, as they say, is history.

Technology has us hooked, cooked and booked. So much so that this need for entertainment, or rather the need to escape into the virtual world, has now become our nemesis. But, is technology to blame solely and entirely?

Dr Neha Patel is a Clinical Psychologist from Mumbai who has years of experience in handling patients suffering from

Internet/device addiction problems. For her, technology is not the evil in this situation, but it surely cannot be ruled out as an accelerator of the problem. "What happens generally is that there are other factors that lead to the addiction. It is because people are trying to escape from something else sometimes, or if they are really bogged down by some other issues. It could be education related, relationship related or anything else," says Patel.

She continues to explain, "Because of so many devices available and also because



someone else has it and you want to have it, so many apps available, the human connect has gone down. We don't even wish people on a one-on-one basis. It's either a message or a Facebook post. Multiple devices have obviously added on to such problems. But, what I always say is that let's not blame the device, it's about how you are using them. It's amazing how many devices are available right now. Earlier, if a person had depression, the issues that would come up because

of it were different. Now, the addiction is different. Technology is easily available and gets caught in the crossfire."

Internet addiction disorder or IAD is a term that's been around for a while now. IAD refers to excessive internet usage, but broadly and in light of the exponential growth of devices, a new term is emerging in the industry. That term is - Digital Dementia. The term was first coined by German neuroscientist Manfred Spitzer in his book with the same name. The book describes how overuse of technology can severely hamper cognitive abilities. Just to put things in perspective, such a breakdown of cognitive abilities also occurs when a person suffers from head injuries or psychiatric illnesses.

Dr Patel asks, "Do you remember phone numbers like you used to before?" Put across to anybody, this question would gather a resounding no. Unless one is blessed with a photographic memory, in today's day and age, no one really dials from memory. This is just one example of the loss in human cognitive abilities over extended periods of using technology. Patel continues to explain how this phenomenon occurs in our brains, "Our brain makes pathways, neural pathways. It's like how a dirt pathway just comes about. Now, those are not happening anymore. Our memory is getting affected majorly."

The truth about how one's own cognitive abilities take a hit is an extremely uncom-